



Olympic trials in June.

Phelps will need to rely on the depth of talent in the men's USA swim team, to secure a gold medal in each three of the relays. There is yet another if: will he be on all of the relays? Several talent-rich countries like Australia, the USA and the Netherlands often have six relay swimmers. Only four swim in the final, but two can be substitutes in the heats, allowing the other two to have a rest. All six are awarded a medal. Phelps won one of his gold medals in Athens by swimming in the heats of the 4x100 medley relay. The relay teams are selected during the competition at the discretion of the US Olympic team coaches.

There are other swimmers that I will be watching closely. I have a personal interest in American Natalie Coughlin because she and her coach Teri McKeever have stayed in my home on training visits to Australia, as my husband Milton Nelms consults with athletes and coaches. In Beijing, seven swimmers he has worked closely with from four different countries will be in action.

There will be many themes and dramas played out during the Games. The new performance-enhancing swimsuits in which 46 world records have been set since February, is another sub-plot. The new generation of swimsuits is a technological change not seen in the sport before. I believe the rules about swimsuits will need to be re-examined and suit-testing protocols developed with the involvement of university science departments.

Going in to Beijing, the talk around the 'record-breaking' suits is mostly about commercial branding opportunities. But clearly, there is new science around human performance in the water that has yet to be clearly defined. The advent of these swimsuits are creating interesting questions in this area.

Another question also arises: if Phelps wins eight gold medals, will he be the greatest Olympian ever? If he won eight gold medals, it would make him the most decorated Olympian ever. But I believe greatness comes from triumph over adversity, serving humanity, being generous and wise.

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After all, the Olympics are just a sporting event, and competing at it is an earned privilege but not an essential life matter.

Phelps' commitment and effort is equalled by many thousands of athletes who will not win medals. The greatest Olympians in my mind are those that embodied the spirit of the movement especially when that was difficult. Who went on to live lives that in retrospect showed that the Olympic ideals were the part of a meaningful life and those whose exploits embodied the hopes or attributes of a nation or a movement or both. Sometimes it takes time for the quality of greatness to emerge. There is more to greatness than winning medals.

In Atlanta when the US organising committee had the chance to have any one from its illustrious past to light the flame, they chose Muhammad Ali. Why not Spitz? Jesse Owens 'only' (sic) won four gold medals in Berlin. In 1936, this was a great achievement. As time passed, the historical relevance of

his victories grew exponentially not only because of what Berlin came to symbolise, but how Owens' humble life compared to the Nazi dream and its demise.

If you ask a Japanese or someone from Africa who is the greatest Olympian, they would have different answers. Can we imagine what it was like for an African to see Abibe Bikkila win the marathon barefoot? Can we imagine the embodiment of Shinto stoicism and what that meant to the people of Japan when Shun Fujimoto stuck his landing with a broken knee to give the Japanese team the gold medal less than a generation after their defeat in a World War?

No, the greatest Olympian will be different things to different people. The important thing for the people of India will be for them to find in their team an athlete or athletes who inspire them to use the canvas of sport to stand for something bigger than themselves.

The Olympic Games though are still what they were originally designed to be for both the participant and the viewer—'inspirational internationalism'. I would like to encourage Indians to use the Olympics as an inspiration to do, not just watch what television sports have become: entertainment, which is a new pressure and skill to master for current athletes. During the 2000 Sydney Olympics, for example, sports equipment sales increased by 40 per cent. Australians didn't just watch, they went out and had a go too.

Sometimes I muse about whether the Olympics should dispense with nationalism, flags and anthems and just cheer for the athlete. The peoples of the world are different, our cultures, food, history, language and customs. This diversity needs to be fostered and celebrated and the Olympic Games is great opportunity to do that.

The author won five swimming medals, including three golds for Australia at the 1972 Munich Olympics.